vandalizing churches and mosques. Two members of the group were indicted in 2015 for torching an historic church on the Sea of Galilee. Many other crimes go unsolved; they are notoriously hard to prosecute. Indeed, they are a group only in the loosest sense of the word. “[They] are working in groups of two to three activists, max,” said Lior Akerman, a former head of the Shin Bet’s Jewish division. “They are not in contact with other gangs. They do not receive instructions from a leader, and they do not hear any guidelines.”

The teenagers arrested in December for the Douma attack were also thought to be Hilltop Youth sympathizers. Investigators spent nearly a week questioning them. But their efforts typically yield little evidence, not least because the detainees have a handbook on how to outsmart the Shin Bet. The manual was written by Noam Federman, a far-right activist who once served as a leader of the Kach party, the political wing of the Kahanist movement. Kach was banned in 1994 and labeled a terrorist organization, but Federman stayed active in extremist circles, and was arrested numerous times on charges of attacking Palestinians. Most of the charges were eventually dropped for lack of evidence.

In his manual, Federman advises his compatriots to ignore summonses for as long as possible, and to choose their words carefully in the interrogation room. Detainees should spend their free time in prayer or studying. “Every person goes to reserve duty or to the army, and that is how you should regard arrest, too,” he wrote. Much of the handbook is devoted to explaining how the Shin Bet uses informants to trick detainees. In one case, he wrote, a jailhouse janitor offered to pass notes between two suspects, only to turn them over to authorities. Other employees have been shown forged newspaper articles claiming that their friends confessed to a crime. “There have been cases in which the Shin Bet brought in a well-known radio announcer and faked news broadcasts,” he added.

Again, their numbers are small, a tiny fraction of Israel’s Jewish population. But their existence underscores Israel’s longtime failure to take seriously the threat of Jewish extremism.

The most prominent member of the Hilltop Youth is Meir Ettinger, 24, the grandson of Meir Kahane, the American-born rabbi whose Kach movement was banned in Israel. He helped to found Ramat Migron, an illegal outpost of another illegal outpost, which was eventually demolished by the government. He then spent the next few years moving from